

SENATE No. 2704

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

SENATE, November 13, 2025.

The committee on Higher Education to whom was referred the petition (accompanied by bill, Senate, No. 945) of Michael O. Moore and James B. Eldridge for legislation to assist low-income students success through work-study, report the accompanying bill (Senate, No. 2704).

For the committee,
Joanne M. Comerford

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**In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)**

An Act assisting low-income students success through work-study.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

SECTION 1. Chapter 15A of the General Laws, as appearing in the 2024 Official Edition, is hereby amended by inserting after section 22A the following section:-

Section 22B. (a) Subject to appropriation, the Massachusetts Association of Community Colleges shall support education opportunity coordinator positions. The coordinators shall work with low-income students, including, but not limited to, recipients of cash assistance through transitional aid to families with dependent children, who enroll in community colleges across the state for the purpose of earning a certificate or 2-year degree. Each community college shall have at least 1 on-campus education opportunity coordinator. In coordination with student support staff funded through line item 7100-4002 of the general appropriation act, said education opportunity coordinators shall provide focused assistance to recipients, including, but not limited to, developing career plans, identifying a program of study and accessing work study opportunities and funding. The coordinators shall work with recipients, community colleges and case managers at the department of transitional assistance and other state agencies as needed. The Massachusetts Association of Community Colleges shall enter into a memorandum of

understanding with the community colleges to ensure coordinators execute the duties of this paragraph.

(b) The Massachusetts Association of Community Colleges, in collaboration with relevant state agencies, shall annually, on or before August 1, file a report with the chairs of the joint committee on higher education, the joint committee on children, families and persons with disabilities and the house and senate committees on ways and means that shall include, but not be limited to: (i) information regarding the efficacy of state work study employment placements and related coursework in developing careers for recipients of cash assistance; (ii) the number of recipients of cash assistance enrolled in certificate or 2-year degree programs at community colleges; (iii) the number of recipients of cash assistance enrolled in a certificate or 2-year degree program receiving grants under the Massachusetts Community College Career Pathways Trust Fund established in section 2KKKKKK of chapter 29; (iv) student success rates including, but not limited to, graduation rates, time to complete a degree and grade point averages, of recipients of cash assistance enrolled in a certificate or 2-year degree program; (v) employment rates of former recipients of grants under the Massachusetts Community College Career Pathways Trust Fund 6 months after completing a degree or certificate program; and (vi) employment rates of former recipients of grants under the Massachusetts Community College Career Pathways Trust Fund 1 year after completing a degree or certificate program. No personal identifying information shall be used in the report.

SECTION 2. Paragraph (B) of section 2 of chapter 18 of the General Laws, as appearing in the 2024 Official Edition, is hereby amended by adding the following clause:-

(t) take all necessary actions, including connecting individuals with education opportunity coordinators established in section 22B of chapter 15A, to ensure that interested individuals receiving cash assistance through transitional aid to families with dependent children are made aware of community college programs in Massachusetts.

SECTION 3. Chapter 29 of the General Laws, as appearing in the 2024 Official Edition, is hereby amended by inserting after section 2JJJJJ the following section:-

2KKKKKK. (a) There is hereby established and set up on the books of the commonwealth a separate fund to be known as the Massachusetts Community College Career Pathways Trust Fund, hereinafter referred to as the fund, to which shall be credited any appropriations, bond proceeds or other monies authorized by the general court and specifically designated to be credited thereto. The Massachusetts Association of Community Colleges, hereinafter referred to as the Association, shall administer the fund and hold the fund in an account or accounts separate from other funds. Amounts credited to the fund shall be used by the Association to carry out the purposes of the fund as set forth in this section. Any monies unexpended at the end of the fiscal year shall remain in the fund and may be expended by the Association without further appropriation.

(b) The fund shall be used to provide and fund state work-study employment opportunities for eligible low-income students enrolled in a certificate or 2-year associate degree program at any community college. Preference shall be given to recipients of cash assistance through transitional aid to families with dependent children.

(c) Funds expended shall, to the greatest extent feasible, be for work-study employment opportunities at: (i) the community college; (ii) an off-campus placement that provides career

development opportunities that are related to the student's course of study; or (iii) an off-campus community service placement as defined in subsection (e).

(d) The share from funds distributed shall not exceed 80 per cent of the total compensation paid to students, with the exception of jobs at the community college the student attends, or that provide career development opportunities related to the student's course of study. Employers shall pay the costs of any employee benefits, including all payments due as an employer's contribution under the state workman's compensation laws, federal Social Security laws and other applicable laws. The federal work-study program shall not be used to provide the employer's share of student compensation.

(e) An off-campus community service placement shall include direct service planning, career development or applied research that is designed to improve the quality of life for residents of the community served, particularly low-income residents, in such fields as health care, child care, education, literacy training, welfare, social services, public safety, crime prevention and control, transportation, recreation, housing and neighborhood improvement, rural development and community improvement. Placements shall be identified by the Association through formal or informal consultation with local nonprofit, governmental and community-based organizations.

The placement shall not be at an organization for whom a majority of its mission is political activities, including but not limited to electing candidates, influencing ballot questions and raising money for political campaigns.

(f) Students shall be paid the rate of pay as compared to entry-level salaries and wages provided other employees engaged in similar work, provided total applicant resources shall be

considered to ensure to the maximum extent feasible that students may remain qualified for other federal and state public assistance programs. The Association may make reasonable adjustments to salaries and wages to maximize a student's participation in other federal and state public assistance programs.

(g) Funds shall not be expended under the program to compensate students for hours worked in excess of an average of 15 hours per week over the period of enrollment or 40 hours per week during vacation period. A student shall not be concurrently employed in the same position by the fund and the federal work-study program and exceed the 15 hours per week average.

(h) Students may receive academic credit for work experience gained through fund jobs.

(i) Monies received from the fund shall not count against a recipient's income, assets or any other eligibility standard in qualifying for cash assistance benefits.

(j) The Association and the department of higher education, hereinafter referred to as the department, shall enter a memorandum of understanding to ensure that funds are properly expended and disbursed. The Association shall enter into agreements with employers, community colleges, the department of transitional assistance and others for the operation of the fund. Said agreements shall include such provisions as the executive office for administration and finance may deem necessary or appropriate to carry out the purposes of this section. Said agreements shall be made available to the department upon request.

SECTION 4. The first report required under subsection (b) of section 22B of chapter 15A of the General Laws, as inserted by this act, shall be filed not later than August 1, 2028.